On a sunny February morning, occasionally swept by a cold breeze, Manipur chief minister N. Biren Singh's convoy left for Saikul assembly constituency in Kangpokpi district, 35 km from state capital Imphal. The cavalcade moved slowly, taking nearly two hours to reach Saikul, a Kuki-dominated area where Singh was to campaign for BJP candidate Yamthong Haokip, a Congress import from last November. Despite the unpaved, potholed stretches along the way, Singh's address to the 700-strong gathering in Saikul did not promise new roads. Instead, he warned militants not to disturb peace which, he claims, has prevailed in Manipur since the BJP came to power in 2017. "If PM Modi can strike terror camps in Balakot, the same can be done against other outfits involved in terrorism," thundered the chief minister.

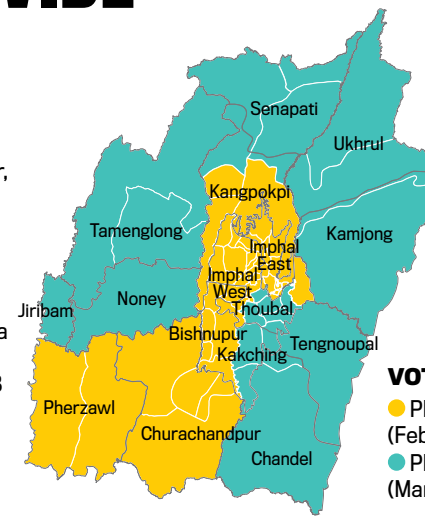
The warning to insurgents has a context. David Hangshing, chairman of the militant group Kuki Revolutionary Army, has forced five BJP members of the Autonomous District Council of Kangpokpi to resign from the party and support his wife Kimneo Hangshing, who is contesting as an Independent from Saikul. Interference by insurgent groups, including threats issued to candidates, is common in Manipur. Civil rights activists also allege a nexus between politicians and insurgents, particularly during elections. Ironically, Hangshing and Haokip were arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in 2018 in a case of weapons missing from the armoury of the 2nd Battalion Manipur Rifles.

A WEB OF COMPLEXITIES

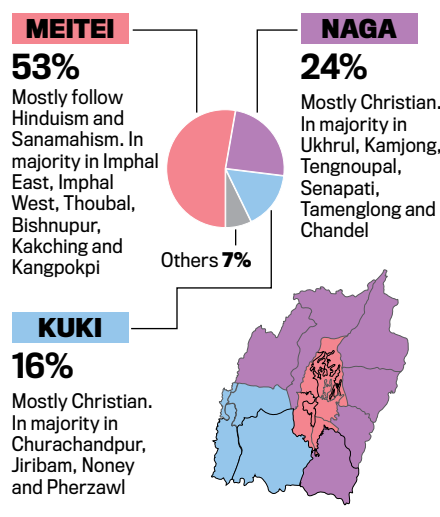
Manipur votes in two phases, on February 28 and March 5. Ethnic undercurrents, the hills-plains divide, influence of militant outfits and money power are known to cast a shadow on elections in the state. Party affiliation rarely matters. The incumbent BJP-led government had two major allies—the National People's Party (NPP) and the Naga People's Front (NPF). While the NPP is contesting the poll on its own, the NPF remains a BJP ally. Yet, in the 15 constituencies that the NPF is contesting, the BJP has also fielded candidates. Last November, the BJP inducted 12 NPF members, in continuation of its policy of poaching "winnable" candidates from other parties.

VALLEY VS. HILLS: THE BIG DIVIDE

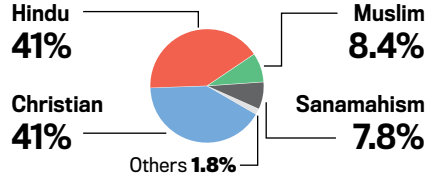
Of the 60 assembly constituencies in Manipur, 40 are in the valley areas spread over six districts—Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangpokpi. The remaining 20 seats are in the other 10 districts. The **valley districts, dominated by Meiteis,** account for just over 11 per cent of the geographical area but are home to 57 per cent of the population. The remaining 43 per cent live in the **hill districts, dominated by the Naga and Kuki tribes.**



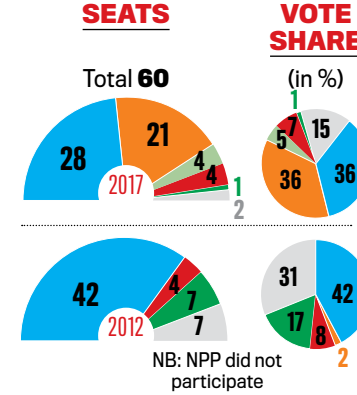
ETHNIC & GEOGRAPHICAL DIVIDE



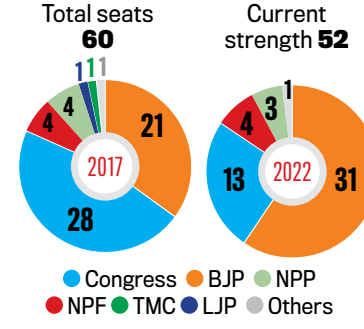
RELIGIOUS DIVIDE



HOW MANIPUR VOTED IN THE PAST



HOW THE MANIPUR ASSEMBLY CHANGED



Graphic by ASIT ROY Source: Census, Election Commission